

Reading Genesis 1 in Its Ancient World

The first chapter of the Bible was answering Babylon, not modern science. Hearing its claims in their own world changes what we ask of them.

OUR ASSUMPTIONS

We Brought the Wrong Question

Open Genesis 1 in an American living room and the questions arrive before the text does. How old is the earth. What about the dinosaurs. Can a thoughtful person still believe this. I have read the chapter that way myself, scanning ancient verses for ammunition in a modern argument.

But Genesis 1 was not written to an American living room. It was written to people who had never heard of geology and would not have cared. Their questions were different. Which god is in charge. Why does the world exist. What are human beings for. Is the sea a monster or a creature.

The first act of reading well is letting the text answer its own questions before we demand answers to ours. That is not a way around the hard conversations. It is the only honest way into them.

ENUMA ELISH

The Story Babylon Told

Babylon had a creation story, and Israel's world knew it. Scholars call it Enuma Elish, from its opening words, when on high. The best copies we possess come from the library of Ashurbanipal at Nineveh, from the seventh century BC, but the composition is centuries older, reaching back into the second millennium.

The story runs on violence. The young god Marduk goes to war against Tiamat, the goddess of the salt sea. He kills her, splits her corpse, and builds the sky from one half and the earth from the other. Then the gods face a labor problem. Someone has to dig the canals, grow the food, and serve the temples. So Marduk has the rebel god Qingu slain and human beings made from his blood. Humanity exists so the gods can rest from their chores.

That was the official theology of the empire that would one day drag Judah into exile. Creation through combat. A world built from a corpse. People made as slave labor. Read that first, and then read Genesis 1 again. The differences are not accidents.

THE CONTRAST

No Battle. No Rivals. No Slaves.

Genesis 1 has no battle. God speaks and the sea simply obeys, because it is water and not a goddess. The great sea creatures, the tanninim that other ancient stories cast as rivals of the gods, show up on day five as one more thing God made and called good.

The sun and moon are not even named. Hebrew had words for them, shemesh and yareach, but those words were also the names of gods worshiped across the region. The text calls them the greater light and the lesser light, lamps hung in the sky to mark days and seasons. Whatever your neighbors worship, Genesis says, God made it. It is furniture.

Then comes the reversal at the center. In Babylon, humans were made from the blood of a condemned god to do the work the gods despised. In Genesis, humans are made in the image of God. In the ancient world, image was the language of kings and idols, the visible representative of a god in his territory. Genesis hands that title to every man and every woman. Not slaves. Image-bearers. There is hardly a more radical sentence in ancient literature.

A SERIOUS PROPOSAL

What If the Week Assigns Functions, Not Materials

John Walton, an Old Testament scholar long at Wheaton College, has argued that we misread the chapter at a deeper level still. In *The Lost World of Genesis One* he proposes that ancient peoples thought about existence in terms of function rather than material. A thing existed when it had a role in an ordered system, the way we might say a company exists once it is organized rather than once its office furniture arrives.

On Walton's reading, the six days are not chiefly describing the manufacture of stuff. They are describing the assignment of functions. Time, weather, food. Then the functionaries who fill each realm, lights to govern, fish and birds to swarm, animals and humans to rule. The climax is day seven, and here the ancient parallels matter most, because in the ancient world a deity rested in a temple, and rest meant taking up residence and command. Genesis 1, Walton argues, presents the cosmos as a temple God moves into and runs.

Be honest about the state of the question. This is a serious proposal from a serious evangelical scholar, and it has persuaded many. It has also drawn substantial criticism, and the debate among scholars is live. You do not have to settle it to receive its central gift, which is the reminder that the chapter is about God

ordering a world for his presence and purposes, not about answering questions from a laboratory it never saw.

THE VERDICT

What Remains When the Argument Ends

Strip the chapter to its claims and they still land with force. One God, not a committee of rivals. A world that is good, not the corpse of a slain goddess. Human beings who bear the image of their Maker, not the chains of his labor shortage.

Genesis 1 was not embarrassed by Babylon. It answered Babylon, point by point, with a quiet authority that needed no battle scenes. Reading the chapter in its world does not shrink it. It lets the text claim what it actually claimed. And none of this makes us better readers than our grandparents. Context is not a credential. It is a posture of listening before speaking.

The oldest question in the chapter is still open. Every culture tells you what a human being is for. Babylon said labor. Our culture says consumption, or performance, or self-invention. Genesis says image. We will spend our whole lives bearing one of those answers.

KEY TEXTS

Genesis 1:1-2:3

Psalms 104:1-9

Isaiah 40:25-26

SOURCES

The Lost World of Genesis One — John H. Walton

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The Bible Among the Myths — John N. Oswalt

The Liberating Image: The Imago Dei in Genesis 1 — J. Richard Middleton